witnesses himself, without access to the depositions against him. Throughout our conversation, he was consistent in his version of events.

I had been apprehensive about meeting Afzal. How would a man on death row feel, and what could I say to someone who would be executed any day? In fact, the black warrant had already been issued. Thankfully, the law provides that if any petition is filed with any authority, the warrant cannot be executed. Afzal had filed a clemency petition; hence, the warrant had been kept in abeyance.

Afzal was calm. I marvelled at his composure. We were meeting as we would have met in any normal circumstances, except that this was inside Tihar Jail, in the office of the deputy superintendent, not even in private. Afzal was telling me the story of his life. He talked about his ordinary life, his employment with several well-known business houses. How could the press say that he was doing ‘odd jobs’, as if there was no dignity in his work? He talked about the fact that he gave tuitions to several well-placed students, whose names he did not wish to disclose to me. He said the press would get hold of the information and he did not want these students, now married and well settled, to live with the stigma that they had been students of Afzal. I tried to persuade him that this information was relevant to sentencing, to show that he was a valuable and trusted member of society. But he refused to give me the names.

He told me that he was kept in solitary confinement and wished to be moved and kept with other prisoners. I asked if he had been reading the newspapers. He said the newspapers were given to him after cutting out all information relating to his case. I was meeting him the day after his elder brother, in a sting operation shown on a TV ‘news’ channel, had said that he (Afzal) was indeed a terrorist and should be hanged.[2] Afzal laughed and said, ‘There is no mystery about that, he is in the care and custody of the STF [Special Task Force].’ His brother had told him that he was in any case condemned to death, why take the rest of the family with him? There was not a trace of bitterness on Afzal’s face as he told me this. He was too strangely cheerful, in a manner I could not understand, for a man facing an unjust death sentence. I asked him about this. His answer was that when the sentence was first pronounced he was nervous and afraid. Now he felt whatever would be would be. It was not with resignation that he was saying this, but with full awareness of the limitations of the system, with knowledge of the role of the